

Weight: Why “I Told You” Does Not Mean “You Received What This Means to Me”

Human-readable companion to Weight: Why the Same Words Do Not Carry the Same Consequence

Human-readable companion to “Weight: Why the Same Words Do Not Carry the Same Consequence.” This companion preserves the scientific claims, limits, and contraction rules of the source manuscript while foregrounding the ordinary human question that motivated it. It is not a separate research contribution.

Abstract

People often communicate as though transmitting a proposition also transmits what that proposition carries for them. It does not. Two people can possess the same content, understand the same sentence, and agree that it is true while it has very different consequences for attention, memory, belief revision, valuation, emotion, policy, or action. The Weight paper proposes a disciplined human-language interface for talking about that difference without turning “weight” into a mysterious substance or universal psychological number. Weight is the consequence something carries for a system relative to the object, the relation being asked about, and the context. Every scientific Weight claim must therefore name the already-defined object, target system, consequence relation, context, and evidence, and must match its evidential status: descriptive, predictive, or causal. Weight is not truth, belief, understanding, emotion, authority, salience, provenance, behavior, or a causal effect by definition. Communication of content does not establish communication of Weight, and an accepted proposition can be present before some of its relevant consequences are present or detectable. The framework survives scientifically only if making these typed declarations improves measurement or inference beyond an equally explicit generic description; otherwise “Weight” should remain useful ordinary language.

1. The ordinary problem hidden inside “I told you”

“I told you” often means much more than “the sentence reached you.” It can mean: I conveyed how serious this was; you knew what it would mean; you should have integrated the consequences; therefore you should have responded the way I would have responded. Those are several different claims compressed into one accusation.

A listener can repeat the statement accurately, explain the literal proposition, and sincerely agree that it is true while it remains comparatively light in the listener’s own system. The sender can then interpret the difference as indifference, denial, stupidity, dishonesty, or refusal. Sometimes those interpretations may be correct. But the mere fact that the content was shared does not establish that its consequences were shared.

same content != same consequence

2. What “Weight” means in this paper

WEIGHT is the consequence something carries for a system, relative to what that thing is, the relation being asked about, and the situation in which it is encountered.

Weight belongs to an already-defined object. A warning can have Weight; a belief can have Weight; a memory, observation, intention, source, anticipated consequence, or emotion can have Weight. The word does not redefine those objects. “Typed” means the parent object keeps the identity supplied by the mature science that already studies it.

- System-relative: the same object can carry different consequences for different people or for the same person at different times.
- Relation-relative: consequence for attention is not automatically consequence for belief, memory, emotion, choice, or action.
- Context-relative: the same representation can become more or less consequential when the surrounding situation changes.
- Evidence-relative: descriptive, predictive, and causal Weight claims require different evidence.

This makes Weight an interface term rather than a universal substance. Its job is to force a speaker or researcher to say what consequence is actually being claimed.

3. The exclusions are more important than the label

Weight is not...	Why not
Truth	A false belief can be highly consequential; a true statement can carry little consequence.
Belief	High credence does not guarantee practical consequence, and low-probability events can dominate policy when stakes are high.
Understanding	A person may explain something deeply without caring about it, or care intensely while understanding it poorly.
Emotion	Feeling may be one object or consequence relation, but strong feeling does not establish decision authority.
Authority	Something can matter greatly and still lose to competing goals, habits, constraints, incentives, or policies.
Salience	What captures attention need not control judgment or action.
Provenance	Where a consequence came from is different from the consequence it currently carries.
Behavior	An endpoint does not reveal every representation, competitor, or causal route that preceded it.
A causal effect by definition	Causal language requires intervention or another valid identification strategy.

These exclusions prevent “Weight” from becoming an explanation that can be retrofitted to any outcome. If a researcher cannot name the object and the consequence relation independently, the claim is not yet scientifically typed.

4. Communication of content does not establish communication of Weight

Language can transfer content with extraordinary efficiency. It does not copy a nervous system, autobiographical history, bodily state, value structure, current goals, or policy hierarchy. A listener may acquire the proposition but not the model behind it. They may acquire the model but not the same consequence. They may accurately infer how consequential the topic is for the speaker without acquiring that consequence themselves.

COMMUNICATION OF CONTENT DOES NOT ESTABLISH COMMUNICATION OF WEIGHT.

Shared reality, empathy, testimony, and grounding research already study nearby relations. Weight does not replace those literatures. It gives ordinary conversation a disciplined way to avoid treating shared words as proof of shared internal consequence.

5. “It did not land” can mean two scientifically different things

People often say that a statement “did not feel real” or “had not hit me yet.” The paper refuses to treat that phrase as one new construct. At least two different situations can produce it.

Case	What is unresolved	Appropriate parent object / relation
The proposition is not yet accepted	The receiver does not assign sufficient credibility to the claim.	Evidence, testimony, source credibility -> belief revision or confidence.
The proposition is accepted but weakly integrated elsewhere	The person can sincerely endorse the proposition while some other consequence remains weak or absent.	The accepted proposition -> memory priority, valuation, affect, policy, action, planning, or another declared relation.

THE PROPOSITION CAN BE PRESENT BEFORE SOME RELEVANT CONSEQUENCES ARE PRESENT OR DETECTABLE.

That sentence does not claim that all consequences must eventually appear, nor that emotion is the missing ingredient. It simply separates possession or acceptance of content from whichever downstream relation is actually being studied.

6. Words, models, consequences, and transfer are four different questions

A recurring communication error is to slide among several levels without noticing. Weight forces them apart.

Question	Possible evidence	What it cannot establish alone
Does the person possess the words/content?	Recognition, recall, paraphrase.	Generative understanding or downstream consequence.
Can the person generate the model or explanation?	Novel explanation, prediction, transfer, derivation.	That the model carries the same local consequence as it does for someone else.
What consequence does the object carry?	Relation-specific attention, belief, memory, valuation, policy, physiological, or behavioral measures.	Where that consequence came from or whether it transfers.
Did communication transfer the consequence?	Pre/post and sender/receiver designs that separately measure content and the target relation.	Internal identity between sender and receiver.

7. Provenance and observer estimates must stay separate from current Weight

Direct experience, testimony, social learning, analogy, training, memory, and bodily state can all contribute to current organization. None guarantees a particular current Weight. Provenance is therefore a different relation: it asks where the present consequence came from.

The same discipline applies to observers. A sender may believe “they understand how serious this is” because the listener can repeat the words, appears calm, or behaves in a certain way. That is an estimate of the listener’s Weight, not direct access to it. The estimate can be accurate or inaccurate and needs its own evidential bridge.

8. A scientific Weight statement needs a typed declaration

The paper proposes an implementation discipline. A Weight statement should make enough of its structure explicit that another researcher can tell what was measured and what the evidence licenses.

Required declaration	Question it answers
1. Object	What already-defined thing is being discussed?
2. Target system	For whom or what is the consequence being claimed?
3. Relation	Consequence for what - attention, credence, memory, affect, policy, action, etc.?
4. Context	Under what situation or boundary does the claim apply?
5. Evidence	What measurement or intervention bears on the claim?
6. Evidential status	Is the claim descriptive, predictive, or causal?
7. Provenance, when relevant	What is known about where the consequence came from?
8. Transfer, when communication is involved	What, if anything, was shown to move from one system to another?

If adding those declarations does not change what is measured, what can be inferred, what must be controlled, or what would count as failure, the scientific use of Weight has not earned itself.

9. There is no universal numerical Weight scale

The same word can be used across belief updating, emotion, memory, risk, attention, motivation, and policy, but the numbers produced by those domains do not become commensurable merely because they are all called Weight. A five-point affect rating, a log-odds belief change, a reaction-time effect, and a choice probability are different measurement objects.

Weight therefore forbids automatic arithmetic across unlike scales. A common numerical metric would require an independently justified mapping or measurement bridge. Without one, the value of the interface is conceptual typing, not universal quantification.

10. The framework can be tested against a simpler control

Because much of the component science is already established, the key empirical question is whether the typed declaration standard does any work beyond generic carefulness. A matched generic-explicitness control can require researchers to specify variables, context, evidence, and claims without using Weight terminology.

If the Weight format improves measurement choices, catches invalid cross-relation inferences, changes preregistered predictions, or produces more reliable interpretation beyond that control, the interface has earned scientific utility. If an equally explicit conventional description performs just as well, Weight should contract to useful ordinary language rather than being defended as a scientific construct.

11. The point of Weight

The paper does not tell people whose feelings or interpretations should win. It does not say that receiving a message requires feeling what the sender feels. It supplies a narrower correction to a common inference: transmitting content is not the same event as transmitting consequence.

That distinction allows statements such as “you heard me,” “you understood the model,” “you believed me,” “this changed your action,” and “this carried the same consequence for you that it carried for me” to be treated as different empirical claims. Weight is useful only insofar as keeping those claims separate makes communication and measurement more precise.

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- The source manuscript contains the complete reference list.*